Design System Token Cleanup Milestone One

What changed in the Figma libraries, how Figma now matches the code, and what comes next. November 2026

Prepared by Digital Transformation Team (User Experience)

Summary

Milestone summary

The design system now holds only what every GCB product needs. Published variables fell from 442 to 161, and Figma matches the code's values.

What we did

Split the tokens into design system and project layers, removed what only Internet Banking uses, and synced Figma to the code.

Why it matters

A small core is easier to learn and to keep in step with code. New GCB products can start from it without inheriting one project's history.

Results

Published variables: 442 to 161.

Core colour tokens: 177 to 56.

Figma and code agree on colour, radius and motion.

Amber and Smoke brands switch with one mode.

Four standard buttons restored.

Where it stands

Figma work is complete for this milestone. The code split and the shared token package are next.

Decisions needed

A GCB GitHub organisation for the package, and four design questions listed at the end.

Context

Why we cleaned up

The first version of the Figma library was copied from the Internet Banking code, so it carried one project's details into the design system.

Too much in the core

442 variables, all published. 79 were illustration colours and 47 were Internet Banking components such as the hero and tiles.

Drift

Eight core colours, the radius scale and the motion values no longer matched the code.

Lost decisions

An earlier cleanup removed the smoke and black button colours because the code did not use them, so the Smoke button had turned amber.

No room to grow

There was no clean way to add a second brand or a second product without copying everything again.

What good looks like

A core that every GCB product shares.

Project tokens kept with the project.

Brand as a switch, not a copy.

Figma and code reading the same values.

Model

How the tokens are organised

Four layers, each with one job. The first three are the design system; the fourth belongs to a project.

Primitives are hidden, so designers only pick tokens that describe a purpose.

Layer	Holds	Example	Who sees it
Primitives	Raw colour ramps and number scales	amber/400, gray/950	Nobody; hidden
Brand	The few values a brand changes, as modes	brand/primary: Amber or Smoke	Set once per project
Semantic	What a colour or size is for	surface/card, status/error, icon/primary	Every designer
Project	What only one product needs	hero/surface, tile, avatar colours	That project's file only

Internet Banking keeps its 44 project tokens as a local NIBS collection in its own Figma file.

Results

Before and after

The library other files receive is about a third of its old size.

Hidden variables still exist in the TOKENS file, so they can be restored, but they no longer reach other files.

Measure	Before	After	Change
Published variables	442	161	Down 64%
Core colour tokens (Theme)	177	56	Down 68%
Variables in the TOKENS file	442	330	Down 25%
Colour primitives designers can see	118	0	All hidden
Illustration variables in the core	79	0	Removed
Core colours that differed from code	8	0	Synced
Standard button types	3	4	Smoke and white restored

Counts from the TOKENS file on 7 November 2026. [CONFIRM: the final publish of TOKENS and CORE COMPONENTS is done]

Alignment

Figma and code aligned

The code is the source of truth for values. Figma was synced to it.

The written rules were updated to match too, so all three now agree.

Area	Was in Figma	Now in Figma and code	Rules
Error red	#dc2626	#ea3446	Unchanged
Focus ring (light)	Pale grey	Dark brown, as in code	Unchanged
Input borders and fills	Five values off	Match code	Unchanged
Radius xl, 2xl, 3xl	12, 16, 20	10, 10, 10	Updated to code
Motion timings	Not in Figma	Code values kept	Updated to code
Primary button label and hover	Raw colours	Brand tokens	Unchanged

The code itself has not been restructured yet. The token package that will generate both Figma and code values is the next phase.

Brand

Brands and buttons

Brand is now a switch. Personal banking uses Amber and business banking uses Smoke, from the same components.

Brand modes

Primary, hover and the text on primary follow the Brand mode. A frame set to Smoke turns every primary button ash, with no copies.

Selected states

Calendar days, selected menu rows and Tertiary buttons now follow the brand too.

Four standard buttons

Primary: the brand colour.

Brand alt: the other brand colour.

Neutral: black, white in dark mode.

Neutral inverse: white, black in dark mode.

Tested on real buttons in Amber and Smoke, light and dark.

Icon colours

Icons have their own three tokens, primary, secondary and on primary, so designers can pick an icon colour from the picker.

Not in code yet

Brand alt and the neutral buttons exist in Figma. They reach the code with the token package.

Progress

Work completed

Seven phases of Figma work are done. Each was checked before and after with a scan of every affected page.

Phase	Work	Result	Status
1	Sync Figma values to the code	9 colours and 3 radius values corrected	Done
2	Clear stray bindings in components	61 bindings repointed; old kit notes removed	Done
3	Merge duplicate tokens	8 duplicates merged; 6 held for a decision	Partly done
4	Hide colour primitives	118 hidden; aliases tested through a publish	Done
5	Brand layer	Amber and Smoke modes; button set rebuilt	Done
6	Move project tokens out	125 removed from the core; 44 kept in Internet Banking	Done
7	Trim dimensions	40 hidden; 1,325 bindings merged with no visual change	Done
8 to 10	Code split, token package, component registry	Not started	Next

Quality

Issues found and fixed

Every change was checked against what designers see. These are the problems the checks caught.

All were fixed. They are listed so the same mistakes are not repeated.

Issue	Effect	Fix
Internet Banking used the library too	Merged icon and text tokens left about 4,830 bindings orphaned	6,032 bindings repaired across 12 pages
Binding a colour reset its opacity	Backdrops turned solid black	Opacity restored and now checked on every write
Local tokens have their own mode	Dark screens showed light values	831 frames given matching modes
Old dark value for glass shade	Icons on amber buttons turned red	Moved to the icon on-primary token
A taller menu row	The last menu item was clipped	Menus set to grow with their content

Older and trash pages in Internet Banking were left as they were, by choice, so some of their bindings show as missing.

Guidance

Adding colours in new projects

New products start from the core and add only what they need. Ask these in order and stop at the first yes.

1. Does a token already mean this?

Use it. Most new colours end here.

2. Is it the project's brand?

Add a Brand mode, plus a colour ramp if the hue is new.

3. Is it only this product's?

Make a local token in the project's own file. The design system does not change.

4. Is it art?

Keep it in the illustration, not in tokens.

Rules that keep it small

A token moves into the core only when a second product needs it.

Core names never include a brand, hue or product.

A dark frame must set both Theme and NIBS to Dark.

Next

What comes next

The Figma side is in good shape. The next milestone moves the same structure into code.

Step	What it involves	Owner and date
Split the stylesheet	Separate core and project tokens in globals.css, with no visual change	[ADD: owner and date]
Token package	Publish @gcb/tokens so every project imports the same values	[ADD: owner and date]
Figma sync	Generate Figma values from the package instead of by hand	[ADD: owner and date]
New buttons in code	Add Brand alt, Neutral and Neutral inverse to the Button	[ADD: owner and date]
Component registry	Share components the same way, once a second product starts	When needed

Decisions

Decisions needed

One setup decision unblocks the next milestone. Four design questions are open.

GitHub organisation

The package needs a GCB organisation on GitHub to be published as @gcb/tokens. The code currently sits under a personal account.

Six held merges

Menu surfaces and four badge text colours differ slightly from the core. Merge them, or keep them.

Mobile typeface

Text in Mobile mode switches to DM Sans, but the house rule is Open Sans everywhere. Which is right?

Icon set

Figma components use Lucide icons; the house rule says Material Symbols.

Glass shade in dark mode

The code makes this colour red in dark mode, which looks like a mistake.

Owner

Each decision needs an owner. [ADD: owners]

Appendix

Supporting work

Everything behind this milestone, in one place.

The plan is the working document. The log records each decision and gap as it happened.

Work	What it contains	File or link
Token plan	The model, the core list, phases and decisions	docs/design-system-token-plan.md
Working log	Decisions, discoveries and open gaps	agents/WORKING_LOG.md
Undo record	Every rebind and deletion, for reversal	scripts/figma/rebind-log-2026-11-07.json
House rules	Radius and motion now match the code	agents/CONSTITUTION.md
TOKENS library	The design system variables	1. TOKENS in Figma
CORE COMPONENTS	Components built on the tokens	2. CORE COMPONENTS in Figma
Internet Banking	Project file with local NIBS tokens	Internet Banking in Figma